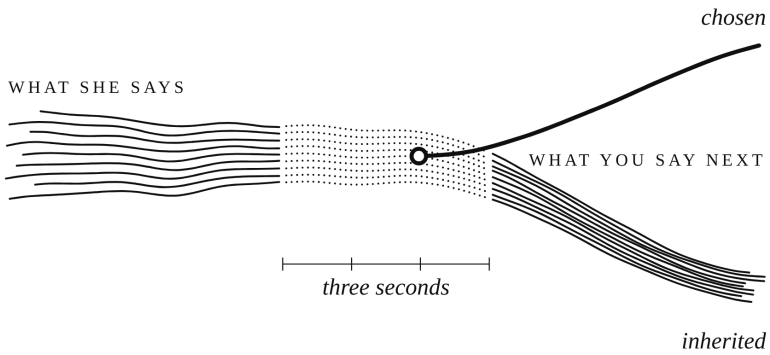
The Gap

Between what she says and what
you say next are three seconds.



Your marriage lives there.

Chapter 1. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 1

The Gap

Intent.

The moment between her words and your reply is a chance to choose your response instead of repeating an old habit.

Visual explanation.

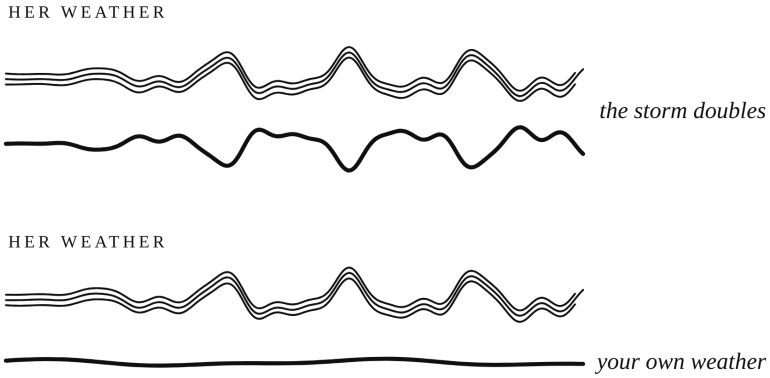
What she says arrives from the left as a current of lines. In the open gap, measured as “three seconds,” the lines run on dotted, not yet said, and unless something changes they slide into the old worn channel marked “inherited.” One bold line leaves the current from a small ring inside the gap and rises to “chosen”: a reply started on purpose. Dotted means not yet said: nothing in the gap has been answered, so either channel is still open.

Validation question.

Where does the current go if nothing is chosen in the gap, and what does the one bold line show the husband can do instead?

The Mood Mirror

When her mood sets your mood,
you've outsourced your peace.



Not to go cold. To bring
something real through the door.

Chapter 2. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 2

The Mood Mirror

Intent.

Bring your own steadiness into the room while remaining caring and engaged, rather than letting her mood determine yours.

Visual explanation.

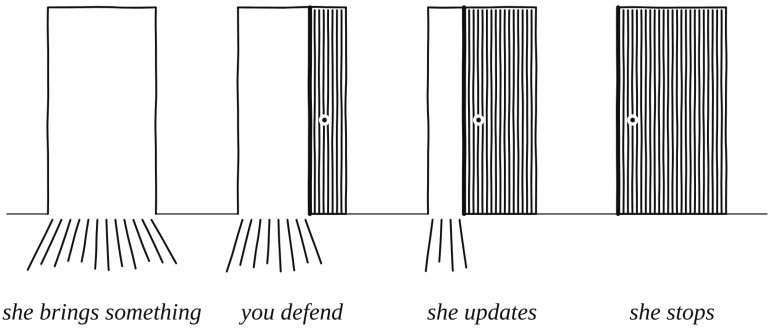
Both rows begin with the same “Her weather”: three close lines, calm at the left and building into a storm. In the upper row his bold line is its mirror image, and the label reads “the storm doubles.” In the lower row his bold line keeps a gentle motion of its own, “your own weather.” His line still moves. The caption, “Not to go cold. To bring something real through the door.”, says that steadiness is not flatness or a wall shutting her out.

Validation question.

Her weather is the same in both rows. What does his line do differently in the lower row, and how would that show up in an evening together?

The Closed Door

Defend yourself enough times, and
she stops bringing you the truth.



—

She's been keeping track
longer than you know.

Chapter 3. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 3

The Closed Door

Intent.

Repeated defensiveness teaches your wife that telling you the truth is not worth the cost. Keeping that conversation open starts with how you receive it.

Visual explanation.

The same doorway appears four times: “she brings something,” “you defend,” “she updates,” “she stops.” Light coming through the opening fans across the floor. Each defence swings the door a third further shut and the light narrows with it, until the door is closed and none reaches the floor. The light stands for her willingness to bring you the truth, not for how much she has left to say.
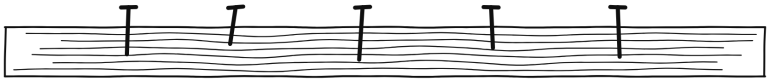
Validation question.

What is being shut out as the door closes, and what is closing it?

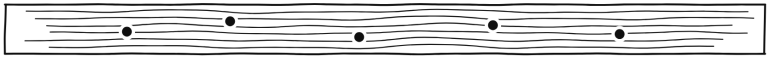
The Hole Maker

Anger isn't strength.

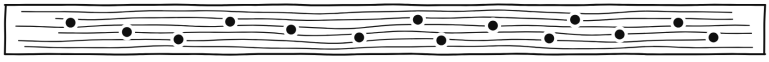
THE OUTBURST — *Every outburst drives a nail.*



THE APOLOGY — *An apology can pull it out.*



MONTHS ON — *It's full of holes.*



———

Sometimes it's cold, and cold
is often worse. Both make holes.

Chapter 4. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 4

The Hole Maker

Intent.

An apology matters, but it does not make the hurt of an outburst disappear. Repeated anger leaves damage that must be taken seriously.

Visual explanation.

The fence board from the father’s story appears three times. “The outburst”: “Every outburst drives a nail.” “The apology”: “An apology can pull it out,” and the nails are gone but their holes sit exactly where the nails were. “Months on”: “It’s full of holes,” and the grain never closes over them. The board represents the relationship carrying the consequences. The caption includes cold anger as well as loud anger, “Both make holes”; the picture warns about repeated harm rather than providing a timetable for repair.

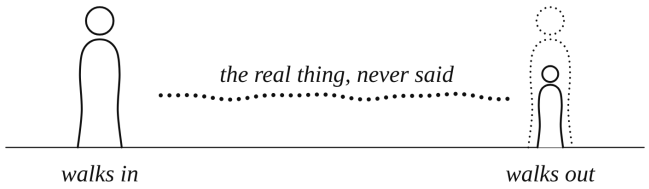
Validation question.

What changes after the apology, what remains, and what does the last board add?

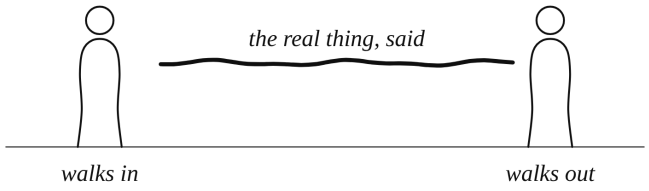
The Courage to Come Back

A pause is only healthy if you come back.

GOES QUIET — *he becomes small without deciding to*



GOES BACK — *he leaves the fight the same size*



Say the real thing before
silence says it for you.

Chapter 5. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 5

The Courage to Come Back

Intent.

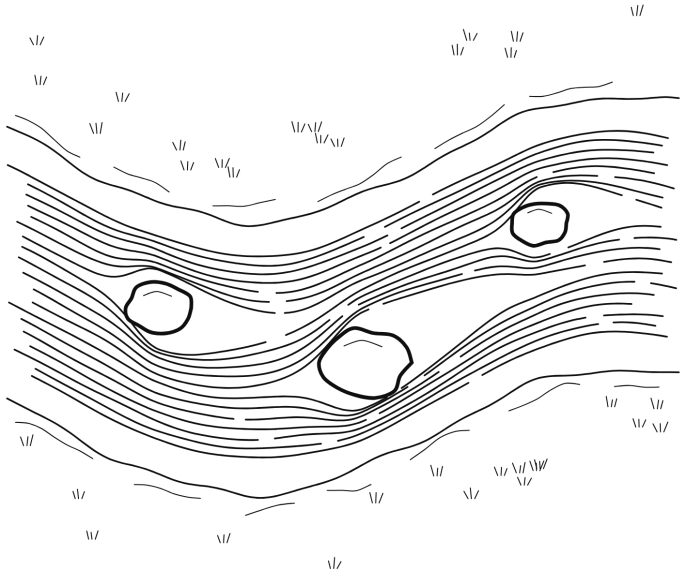
A pause helps only if you return to the unresolved concern and speak plainly. The plate uses “The Courage to Come Back”; the distillation still names “The Remaining Nails.” That naming discrepancy remains unresolved.

Visual explanation.

The same man walks in twice. In “Goes quiet,” he walks out smaller, with the dotted outline of the size he walked in at still standing around him, and the line across the room is dotted: “the real thing, never said.” In “Goes back,” he walks out the same size and the line is solid: “the real thing, said.” Keeping his size means keeping his voice and self-respect, not winning the argument or securing her agreement.

Validation question.

Why does the man walk out smaller in the upper row, and what makes the lower row different?



The stone drops in,
and the current keeps its pace.

Part I. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Part I: The Steady River

Intent.

Steadiness is repeated daily practice. Patiently holding your direction through difficulty can shape a marriage over time.

Visual explanation.

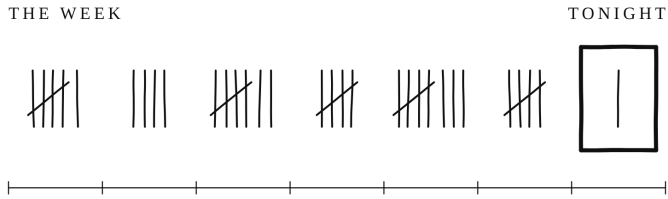
A river crosses the page between two banks, with three stones in the current. The lines of water part around each stone, pass it, and close up again downstream, and the river keeps its course. The caption reads “The stone drops in, and the current keeps its pace.” The stones are the difficulties; the river neither fights them nor stops for them. Steadiness here is holding direction, not pushing the stone out of the way.

Validation question.

What does the water do when it meets a stone, and what might that suggest about a husband’s daily choices?

The Tally You Don’t Read Aloud

You are counting the week.
She can only see tonight.



Resentment grows when you expect someone to read a tally you never showed them.

Chapter 6. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 6

The Tally You Don’t Read Aloud

Intent.

What your wife sees tonight may be only a small part of what you contributed this week. Expecting her to know the unseen total feeds resentment; notice each other’s work rather than defending a private score.

Visual explanation.

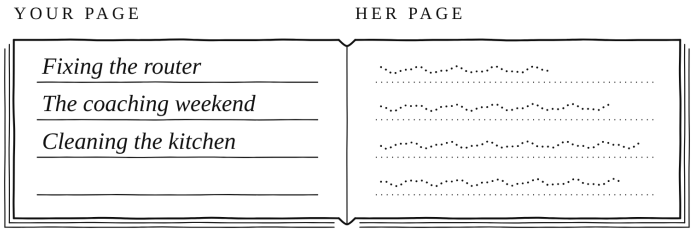
Seven days of tally marks run under “The week”: everything he has been counting. One bold frame surrounds the last day, “Tonight,” and it holds a single mark. The frame is what she can actually see. The marks outside it still happened; the frame represents the limited view available in the moment, not the full measure of either spouse’s contribution.

Validation question.

What is inside the frame compared with the rest of the week, and why might that difference matter at home?

The Private Tally

The ledger can only count what it can see.



a ledger you can't fully read



the smaller things neither of you tracks

Half the data, and it
always says you're ahead.

Chapter 7. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 7

The Private Tally

Intent.

Your mental score cannot fairly measure who gives more because you know your own contributions best and miss much of hers. Give with care and appreciate what you cannot count.

Visual explanation.

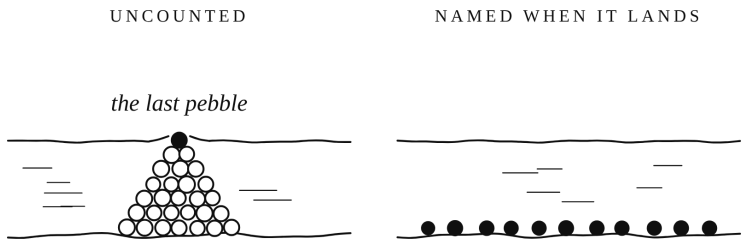
An open ledger. “Your page” has three entries you can read: “Fixing the router,” “The coaching weekend,” “Cleaning the kitchen.” “Her page” is just as full, but every line is dotted: “a ledger you can’t fully read.” Her page is unavailable to you, not empty of effort. Beneath the book, a field of small marks is “the smaller things neither of you tracks.” Together, these show why a private tally is incomplete.

Validation question.

What can you read on each page, and what do the marks beneath the book suggest about keeping score?

The Tipping Scale

Unfairness rarely arrives as one moment.



The last pebble is rarely the whole weight.

Chapter 8. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 8

The Tipping Scale

Intent.

A grievance that feels sudden may carry weeks of small, unnoticed disappointments. Notice and address things as they happen instead of treating the last incident as the whole problem.

Visual explanation.

Two stretches of still water over a riverbed. Under “Uncounted,” pebbles have settled into a mound beneath the surface, where none of it shows, until one dark pebble on top, “the last pebble,” lifts the surface. That one is all he sees. Under “Named when it lands,” the same number of pebbles lie in one layer and the water stays calm. The caption reads “The last pebble is rarely the whole weight.” The contrast is unacknowledged versus acknowledged, not an instruction to keep both spouses’ scores equal. Naming something does not by itself guarantee resolution.

Validation question.

Why does the surface break on the left and not on the right, and what does the last pebble mean?

The Bottomless Yes

You never named the deal,
so she never agreed to it.

EVERY YES YOU GAVE	SOMETHING BACK
A night you did everything she wanted	*Respect*
A plan you went along with, not yours	*Warmth*
Her story, heard all the way through	*Being heard*

you never asked for it

a list only you are keeping

Say what you need before
generosity becomes debt.

Chapter 9. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 9

The Bottomless Yes

Intent.

Giving while silently expecting a return can become resentment over a deal your wife never agreed to. Say what you need clearly before generosity becomes a private debt.

Visual explanation.

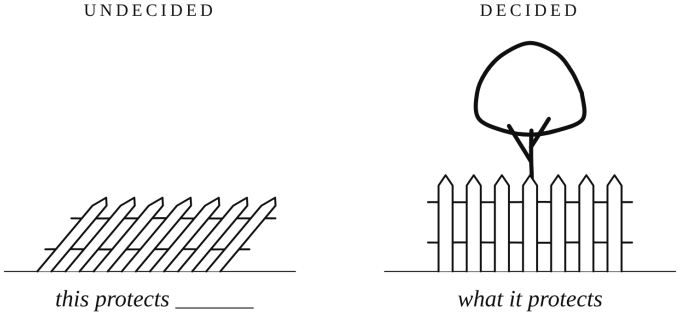
A bill he wrote and never handed over, torn along the bottom. Under “Every yes you gave” are items such as “A night you did everything she wanted,” each joined by a dotted leader to what he expected under “Something back”: “Respect,” “Warmth,” “Being heard.” Where the total would be, it reads “you never asked for it.” Below the tear: “a list only you are keeping.” The picture describes an unspoken bargain, not proof that she owes repayment or gives nothing.

Validation question.

What did each yes expect back, and what does the line where the total should be tell you?

The Undecided Line

If you cannot name what it protects,
it is probably a preference.



Chapter 10. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 10

The Undecided Line

Intent.

Before defending a boundary, be able to say what it protects. A named purpose gives you something more solid than an unexplained preference to hold and discuss.

Visual explanation.

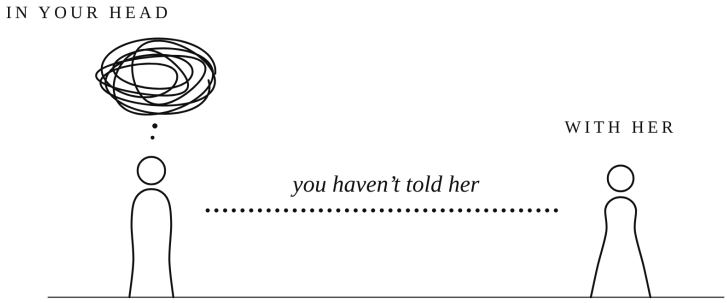
A boundary is drawn as a picket fence. Under “Undecided,” the fence stands around nothing and has folded over; its label, “this protects,” ends in a blank line. Under “Decided,” the same fence stands upright around a young tree, “what it protects,” and holds. The tree is the one bold thing: a clear reason for the boundary, not force applied to your wife.

Validation question.

What keeps the right-hand fence standing, and how would you name that in an actual disagreement?

The Conversation She's Never Heard

You keep arguing with her in your head.



Tell her what's bothering you.
Then listen.

Chapter 11. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 11

The Conversation She’s Never Heard

Intent.

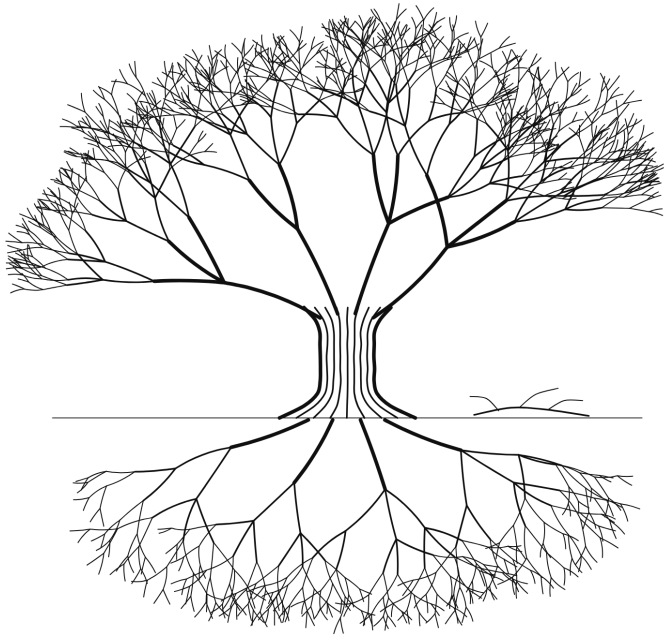
Rehearsing an argument in your head does not tell your wife what is bothering you. When the problem needs a conversation, explain it kindly, ask clearly, and listen without demanding immediate agreement.

Visual explanation.

Over the man’s head, a tangle of loops is the whole argument, “In your head,” going round. She is standing across the room, “With her.” The only thing between them is a dotted line, “you haven’t told her,” because none of it has been said. “Tell her what’s bothering you. Then listen.” supplies the next action; the dotted line does not mean she has refused to listen.

Validation question.

Where is the argument happening, and what would turn the dotted line between them solid?



The storm comes through,
and in the morning the
oak is still there.

Part II. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Part II: The Sturdy Oak

Intent.

Be dependable through difficulty. Strength includes continuing to offer support after hard seasons have left their mark.

Visual explanation.

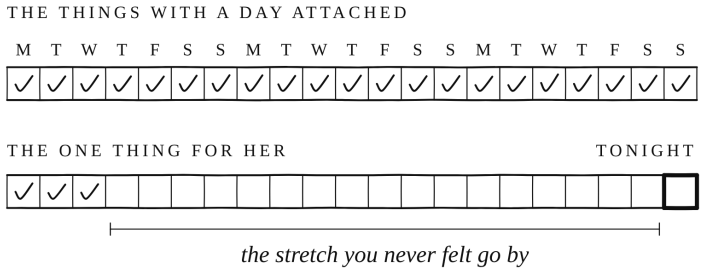
A broad oak the morning after a storm: bare, with one limb down on the ground beside it, and the trunk and roots untouched. The roots go as deep below the ground as the crown is tall above it. The caption reads “The storm comes through, and in the morning the oak is still there.” The fallen limb shows the storm left its mark. The image is meant to show lasting through difficulty, not a life without damage or strain.

Validation question.

What has the storm done to this tree, what has it not done, and what kind of strength might that represent in a husband?

The Thing With No Deadline

What has no deadline is easiest to neglect.



You didn't stop loving her.
Love rarely becomes urgent.
That is why you have to make room for it.

Chapter 12. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 12

The Thing With No Deadline

Intent.

Romance is easy to neglect because nothing makes it urgent. Make room for care that is specifically for her before another week disappears.

Visual explanation.

Two strips from the same three weeks of calendar. “The things with a day attached” has a tick in every square. “The one thing for her” has ticks in its first three squares, then empty squares, “the stretch you never felt go by,” up to a bold open square at “Tonight,” an opportunity still available. The contrast is between what the schedule demands and what you must choose to make room for; the squares are illustrative, not measured data.

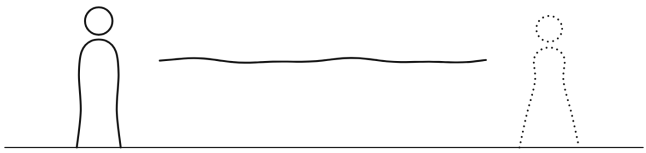
Validation question.

What accounts for the empty stretch on the lower strip, and what does the bold square at the end offer?

Keep learning her after you've won her

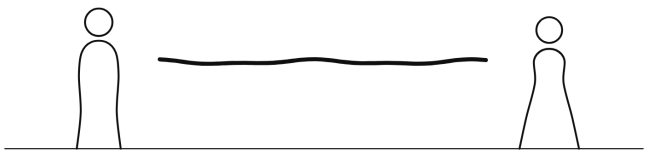
One thing she'd be excited about this Saturday.

PLANNING A DATE



what she liked at twenty-six

ASK HER *and ask about it again later in the week*



who she is now

You can love her and keep doing things for her, and still have stopped being curious about who she is now.

Chapter 13. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 13

Keep learning her after you've won her

Intent.

You can love your wife and keep doing things for her, and still have stopped being curious about who she is now. Keep learning who she is now, and ask again.

Visual explanation.

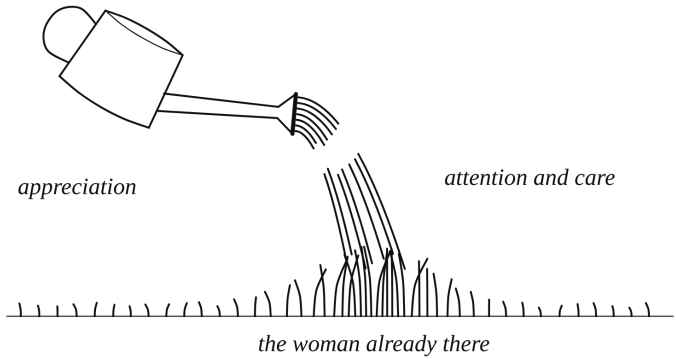
The same man, two ways of finding the chapter's own test, "One thing she'd be excited about this Saturday." In "Planning a date," a plain line runs from him to a dotted woman: "what she liked at twenty-six." In "Ask her and ask about it again later in the week," a bold line reaches a solid woman: "who she is now." The takeaway under the drawing is the idea in one sentence: you can love her and keep doing things for her, and still have stopped being curious about who she is now. It concedes the love and the effort, so the upper row reads as real effort on old information, not as the wrong move and not as an accusation. It does not say that remembering is useless. The chapter says remembering the answer is what she notices.

Validation question.

Both lines reach a woman. Why is one of them dotted, and what does the lower row do that the upper does not?

Appreciation becomes care

Notice what you value in your wife.



The grass is greener where you water it.

Chapter 14. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 14

Appreciation becomes care

Intent.

Notice what you value in your wife and let appreciation become an ordinary act of care for the life you share.

Visual explanation.

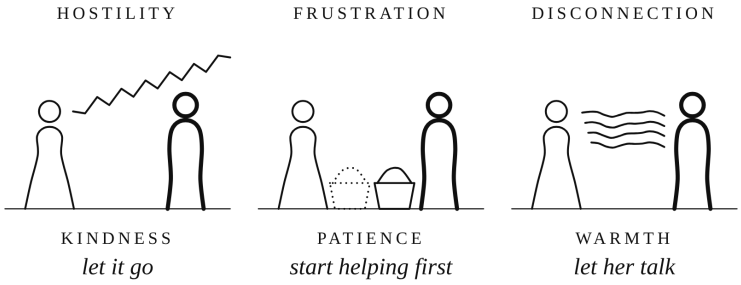
A watering can labelled “appreciation,” tipped to pour; its loop handle, body, long spout and flared rose make the object recognizable. Water leaves the rose in fine arcs, “attention and care,” and lands on one stretch of grass, “the woman already there.” The grass stands tall and thick exactly where the water lands and thins out on either side. The caption is the chapter’s line, “The grass is greener where you water it.” The image draws appreciation becoming care through contact between water and grass. The grass is already there; the water does not grow her into something else, which is the chapter’s idea of enough. There is no before/after comparison or returning arrow.

Validation question.

Within ten seconds, can a stranger recognize a watering can watering grass, identify attention and care as the water, see why the grass is thickest where it lands, and understand appreciation for the woman already there becoming care? Does the image imply she owes a response?

Meet hostility with kindness, frustration with patience, disconnection with warmth

When your wife's day turns sharp.



"Was I the best part of her day?"

Chapter 15. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 15

Kindness answers the zing

Intent.

When your wife says something sharp, hear it as a sign of how she feels, help before you answer, and ask yourself whether you were the best part of her day.

Visual explanation.

Three small scenes with the same two people; he is the bold figure. Above each is what her day brings, below it what he meets it with. “Hostility,” “Kindness,” “let it go”: her sharp remark, a jagged line, goes past his shoulder and keeps going. “Frustration,” “Patience,” “start helping first”: the basket that was at her feet, now dotted, stands at his. “Disconnection,” “Warmth,” “let her talk”: her words reach him and he says nothing back. Nothing jagged goes back in any scene. The deck reads “When your wife’s day turns sharp.” and the caption, in the chapter’s quotation marks, “Was I the best part of her day?” The question is his, asked of himself; it is not a promise. His silence in the third scene is listening, not withdrawal.

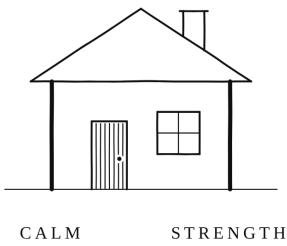
Validation question.

Without the chapter, does each scene read as him taking something from her day rather than returning it, and does the third read as letting her talk rather than ignoring her?

Calm and strength make the marriage sound; warmth makes it a home

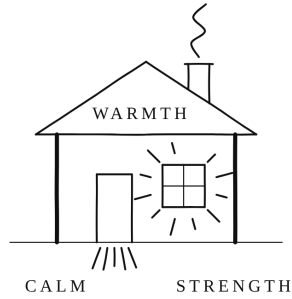
Warmth is what the calm
and the strength were for.

calm alone can go cold



structurally sound

small, warm things



a home

At peace, at its best, and flourishing.

Chapter 16. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Chapter 16

Calm and strength make the marriage sound; warmth, kept up every day, makes it a home and puts it in flow

Intent.

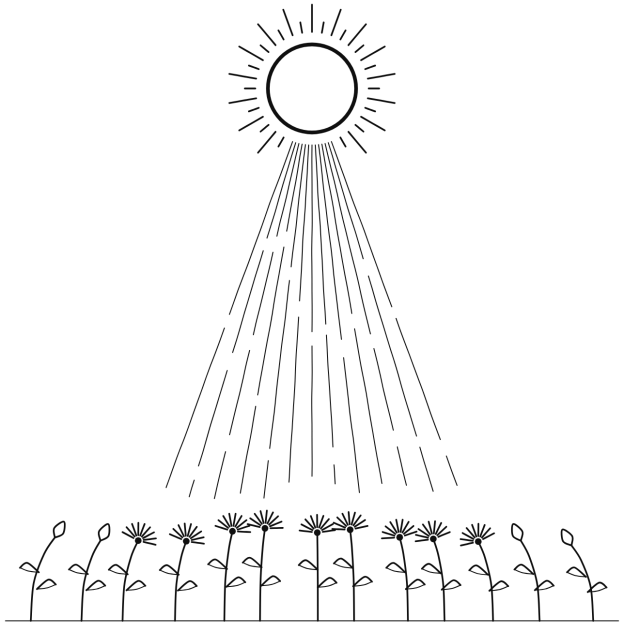
Calm and strength make the marriage sound, but calm alone can go cold; warmth, kept up every day, is what makes the sound house a home, and with all three at once the marriage is at peace, at its best, and flourishing.

Visual explanation.

The same house twice, mirrored about the centre. Its two bold walls are “Calm” and “Strength,” labelled separately as two qualities in him. On the left that is all there is: the door shut, the window unlit, “calm alone can go cold” above and “structurally sound” below. On the right, under “Warmth” at the eaves, the window is lit, the door stands open with light on the step, and smoke rises from the chimney; “small, warm things” above, “a home” below. The walls are the same in both, so warmth is what turns a sound house into a home. Deck: “Warmth is what the calm and the strength were for.” Closing line: “At peace, at its best, and flourishing.” The image is the chapter’s own house, calling back the Introduction’s “A house can be structurally sound and still feel cold”.

Validation question.

Without the chapter, do the lit window, open door and smoke read as what turns the sound house into a home, or as decoration on a house that was already finished? Do the walls read as two qualities in him, or as him and her?



What it reaches, opens.

Part III. Before turning the page: what do you think this image is saying about marriage?

Part III: The Warm Sun

Intent.

Offer warmth consistently through attention, affection, and generosity. Warmth invites openness without demanding gratitude or a particular response.

Visual explanation.

The sun stands over a row of flowers, and every stem leans toward it. A cone of fine rays reaches down to the middle of the row; where that light falls the flowers are open, and beyond it they are still shut. The caption reads “What it reaches, opens.” Nothing pulls the flowers open; the light only reaches them. The shut buds at either end are not refusing anything; the light has not reached them.

Validation question.

Why are some of the flowers open and others shut, and what feeling or action in a marriage does that bring to mind?